They live in little huts of mud and concrete blocks, corrugated iron roofs, row after row. Fairly adequate medical service is provided, probably better than was enjoyed before they were expelled from their native villages.

Children swarm everywhere. There are primary schools for nearly all of them. There are secondary schools for many of the adolescents. And what will these youths and girls do when they have finished their secondary school training? There is no employment for them in the [Gaza] Strip, and very few can leave it to work elsewhere. The Gaza Strip resembles a vast concentration camp.

They can look to the east and see wide fields, once Arab land, cultivated extensively by a few Israelis.

(General Burns, a UN Commander, describes the conditions in the camps in Gaza in the 1950s)

The plight of the refugees

The UN wished to **repatriate** the refugees, but the Israelis refused to allow them to return to their lands in Israel. Instead, the Israelis continued to take over Arab villages and to confiscate the property of Palestinians who had fled from Israel. Much of this 'absentee property' was given to new Jewish immigrants. The Israeli 'Law of Return' allows any Jew anywhere in the world to go and live in Israel but forbids Palestinians to do so.

Key question
Was there a solution to the refugee problem?

Repatriate
To send people back to their own country.

Key term



A refugee camp in Jordan 1949. Of which of the conditions described in the extracts on pages 77–8 can you see evidence in the photograph?